us into the ground with his famous 10-wicket haul.

But neither Test went into the fifth day, so mediocre was the batting in both teams. Clearly, it was a series that belonged to the spinners. In Chennai, I got Sourav Ganguly's wicket – he was India's highest scorer of 54 in their first innings – and then went on to clean up the tail. Saqlain Mushtaq, by then one of my best friends, got a five-wicket haul in each innings of that series at an average of 20.15 and was awarded Man of the Series. On the Indian side, Kumble was the pick of their bowling and took advantage of an inconsistent home umpire in the first Test, but also brilliantly used the pitch – paved courtesy of the Shiv Sena – to crush us for a perfect 10 at the Feroz Shah Kotla Stadium in Delhi.

Kumble wrapped up the series with 21 wickets at an average of 14.85. What a guy! Even though I was the highest scorer for Pakistan in that second Test, I couldn't dominate him fully in that series.

For me, there were other lows on that tour – mostly within the Pakistan dressing room. During my innings of 141 at Chennai – off 191 balls, for over six hours of play, with 21 fours and 3 sixes where I went after Javagal Srinath and Co. – everybody in my team knew that Javed Miandad, the coach, didn't want me in the side.

The tussle had started even before the series kicked off. Miandad had developed a strong opinion against me, but Wasim Akram put his foot down, saying that if I didn't play, he wouldn't either. Of course, the skipper won and I tagged along. But the tension persisted and Miandad didn't relent. In fact, the day before I went to bat, Miandad didn't even give me any net practice. So I had to practise on a stringed ball, alone, away from my teammates. That was the cloud of angst and embarrassment under which I was playing my first Test against Pakistan's greatest rival. Imagine what I could have done with his support, considering what I managed to achieve without it.

In retrospect, I found Javed bhai very different from the hero we had grown up to cherish in the 1980s. Moreover, the conflict between the two of us was personal: about style, method and technique. He wanted me to play the way he played. He hated the way I batted. He didn't like my style, my technique or the lack of it. For me, batting was all about power plays and not exploiting gaps, but forcing your way into them. By that stage in my career, I knew I wasn't technically orthodox, but I had a thing going and it was working on the field as well as for the rest of the squad. But not for Javed bhai. He couldn't digest the way I played. I don't know why he took himself so seriously.

Our conflict had made things tough even before the tour had begun. His contrarian view about my place in the side added to a lot of team politics and anxiety on the tour. Instead of me, he wanted Asif Mujtaba in the side. It was only upon Wasim Akram's insistence and the chief selector Salahuddin Satti's suggestion that I made the cut. The stage was set for a disaster. Javed bhai was relentless. And that's how the day before the Chennai match, he did something I consider highly unethical and unprofessional by not letting me bat at the nets. Bear in mind that I was the opener.

Of course, I played the match, scored that century and we even won the game by 12 runs. But Javed bhai's attitude towards me touched a new low. Before the post-match presentation ceremony, he pulled me aside and said, 'Listen, buddy, you'd better make sure you thank me in the presentation and interview. Tell them how I've groomed you and made you a good batsman.